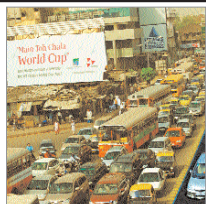




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Lead Feature

You're Being Watched

Whether it's in your office, a changing room, on vacation, at a friend's place...technology has enabled spying on you. Will you ever be safe?

Robert Sovereign-Smith

A Google search for "MMS Scandals" brings up over 3 lakh results, but what's worrying is the fact that the first few results scream "DPS MMS, Preity Zinta, Mallika Sherawat, Nude Riya Sen Pictures...", or something to that effect. We Indians seem to have turned voyeur, and the sheer number of video clips of unsuspecting women or couples caught on camera in the most compromising of situations is testimony to that.

Web sites proudly proclaim "Desi" content, with the most popular sites offering voyeur videos of everyday Indian women. Not all these videos or pictures contain nudity, but they certainly are all sexual in nature. Popular forums and blogs, visited by a lot of Net-savvy young Indian men and women, contain content that is filmed without the subjects' permission.

Take the example of a forum that has mainly Indian members who share pictures and video clips that they've shot / found of Indian men / women (you really thought we'd link you to it, didn't you?). Though the site has loads of pornography and MMSes, surprisingly, the most popular threads are those that are filled with "aunties" (forum slang for women between the ages of 25 and dead) in regular clothes, just going about everyday work, such as hanging up clothes, or sweeping their balconies! No nudity is required, just a little skin showing! Amateur photographers-turned-voyeurs click these pictures and post them online, where members come and make derogatory and sexual remarks about them. If you think this is limited to a few big cities, you should know that this writer has seen pictures posted by people from Nasik, Baroda, Mumbai, Pune, Bangalore, Kolkatta, Delhi, Lucknow, Kanpur, Imphal, Udaipur, Ranchi, Gwalior... a never-ending list!

Omnipresence

Technology has invaded our lives, and though most of it is good, there are negative aspects to everything. Take the mobile phone, for instance:

what was an elitist device a decade ago is now a tool for the masses. But what's causing the problems is the falling prices of camera phones. With higher-end phones now sporting in excess of 3-megapixel cameras, the older VGA models have become bare minimum for anyone buying a mobile today. It's not even a feature anymore; it's just there!

While a lot of us will use this technology to click pictures of our families, pets, or nature, others will try and misuse it for voyeuristic purposes. Arming everyone from teenagers to adults with an easily concealable camera will obviously have repercussions.

A chat with one of the people (anonymity requested) who posts such pictures on forums and sites explained a lot:

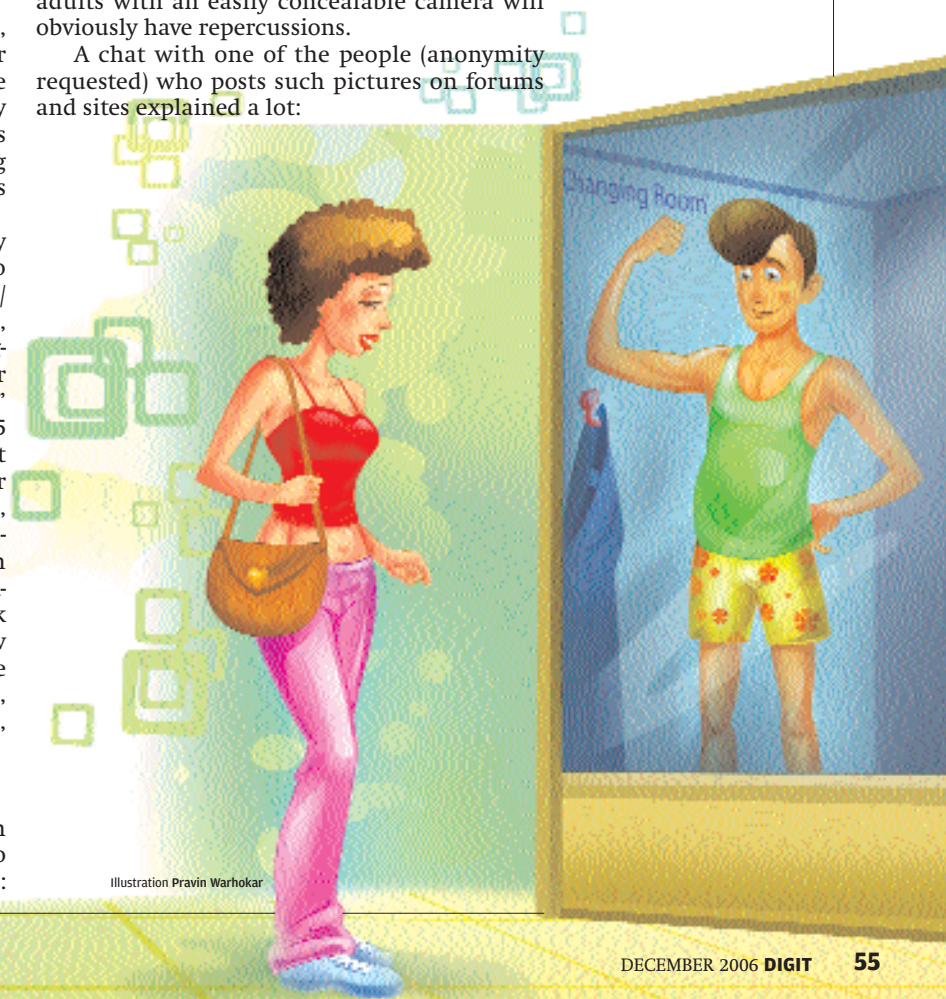


Illustration Pravin Warhokar